Bhubaneshwar, in 1990.

The Buddhists and Jains saw the elephant as a symbol of unmanageable brute power brought under control by the dharma of their respective faiths. Emperor Ashoka obviously thought likewise, using the elephant as a symbol of his vision of dharma. The half-carved elephant that guards the Dhauli edicts is echoed in another elephant carved above another set of Ashokan REs several thousand miles away at Kalsi in the Himalayan foothills. Here and at virtually every other surviving RE site these edicts have been cut into the sides of huge rounded boulders deliberately chosen for their elephantine appearance.

Although Buddhism was already taking a more outgoing course than Jainism as a proselytising religion, the Buddha's teachings had made little impact outside Maghada – until Ashoka began to propagate the Buddhist dharma alongside his own ethics-based Dharma as set down on his rock edicts. His first action was to redistribute the original cremated remains of the Buddha, which had been buried under eight simple mounds, or stupas. These remains were now divided into fragments and placed in new stupas built throughout his empire – supposedly eighty-four thousand of them but more likely something closer to eighty-four. These early stupas were no more than simple brick domes enclosed within wooden railings. Under the direction of Ashoka's religious commissars, known as *mahamatya*s, the veneration of the stupa as the embodiment of the Buddha became a quintessentially Buddhist phenomenon, briefly copied by the Jains with their own saints.

This stupa-building programme in conjunction with Ashoka's edicts impacted so dramatically on the landscape as to make Ashoka's name known in almost every corner of the land. A further boost came in the wake of a great Buddhist gathering convened by Ashoka in his capital in Pataliputra (modern Patna in Bihar) in about the year 250